

Great crested grebe

Podiceps cristatus

Great crested grebes are renowned for their courtship rituals. One bird swims with the head and bill extended low on the water, then dives suddenly to reappear almost beneath its partner. The two perform “weed ceremonies” and dances. The nest is a mass of damp weed, which covers the eggs if a parent leaves the nest unattended. The stripy-headed chicks whistle to beg their parents for fish.

- ↔ 18–20 in (46–51 cm)
- ⚖ 1–3 lb (0.5–1.4 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐟 Fish
- 🏠 Europe, Asia, Africa, Australia, New Zealand

▽ MALE AGGRESSION

Male great crested grebes may fight over territorial boundaries during the breeding season.



Hoopoe

Upupa epops

Hoopoes spend most of their time foraging quietly on the ground, picking and probing with their bill in search of insects. Singing hoopoes spread their crests vertically, like a fan, giving low, far-carrying “hoop-hoop-hoop” calls from a tree or rooftop. They nest in tree cavities, which quickly become foul with the chicks’ droppings and rotten food waste.



fan-shaped crest with black tips

- ↔ 11 in (28 cm)
- ⚖ 3 oz (85 g)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐛 Insects, earthworms, snails
- 🏠 Europe, Asia, Africa

△ SWIRL OF COLORS

A hoopoe returning to its nest catches the eye in a flurry of black and white feathers.

Jeweled lizard

Timon lepidus

Europe’s largest lizard—the jeweled, eyed, or ocellated lizard—gets its name from the blue “eyes” or rosettelike markings on its flanks. Its head and body are stocky, while the tapering tail makes up three-fifths of its length. The lizard hunts by day in mainly open, drier habitats. It hibernates in an old burrow or tree root for two to three midwinter months, and breeds in early summer. The female hides her clutch of 8–25 eggs in loose soil or

undergrowth. If threatened by a predator, the jeweled lizard defends itself by opening its mouth and hissing. It also bites very hard and can be difficult to dislodge.

▽ COLORFUL MALE

The male jeweled lizard is larger and heavier, and more colorful, than the female.

- ↔ 20–32 in (51–81 cm)
- ⚖ Up to 1 lb (0.5 kg)
- ⊗ Near threatened
- 🐛 Insects, frogs, mammals
- 🏠 SW. Europe



SW. Europe

